It has been already remarked that the last hope of a settlement faded away when the Conservatives were returned to power. Their estimate of the Indian situation as also of the India leader, was quite different from that of the Labourites His goodness, his frankness, his humble ways, his profound consideration for his opponents—not only did not impress John Bull, but was construed as weakness His habit of putting all his cards on the table was all right for India and the Indians, but damaged his prestige among British politicians His proneness to confess his ignorance on intricate questions of finance or law would have been all right in the company of truth-seeking philosophers, but lowered him in the estimation of the British public who were accustomed to see their leaders looking more wise than they really were His repeated offer of wholehearted co-operation at the Round Table Conference had a most tragic effect and made them think—'Gandhi is on his last legs' What impression could such a statement make on a veteran politician in England? 'I shall be here as long as I am required, because I do not want to revive civil disobedience I want to turn the truce that was arrived at at Delhi into a permanent settlement But for heaven's sake give me, a frail man sixty-two years gone, a little bit of chance Find a little corner[1] for him and the organisation that he represents'[2] If, on the contrary, the Mahatma had spoken in the language of Dictator Stalin, or Il Duce Mussolini or Fuehrer Hitler—John Bull would have understood and would have bowed his head in respect As it was, the Conservative politicians began to think 'Is this frail man in loin-cloth so formidable that the powerful British Government should yield to him? India was being ruled by a man who was fit to be a bishop and so we had so much trouble If only we had a strong man at Delhi and at the India Office—everything would be all right' This is how the Indian situation was summed up after the General Election of October 1931 And all his propaganda among Church dignitaries, professors and cranks was of no use to India The secret of political bargaining is to look more strong than you really are Indian politicians, if they want to match themselves successfully against their British opponents will have to learn many things which they do not know and unlearn many things which they have learnt

[1] It is to be regretted that they cornered him successfully

[2] The Mahatma's speech at the plenary session of the Round Table Conference on November 30th 1931